

EXCEL STACKED COLUMN CHART

06

Show totals and what they are made of

WHEN TO USE

- Data has **categories** split into **components** (e.g., Month x Product Category).
- Answers: **How big is the total, and what makes it up?**
- Use it to compare **totals over time** while keeping the composition visible.

BUSINESS QUESTION

- How did total monthly sales change?
- Which category drives each month's sales?
- Is Software growing over time?

DATA EXAMPLE

	A	B	C	D
1	Month	Laptops	Accessories	Software
2	Jan	60	25	15
3	Feb	65	30	15
4	Mar	80	35	20
5	Apr	75	40	25

DATA ANALYST USE CASE

Example: **Sales Mix**

QUESTION

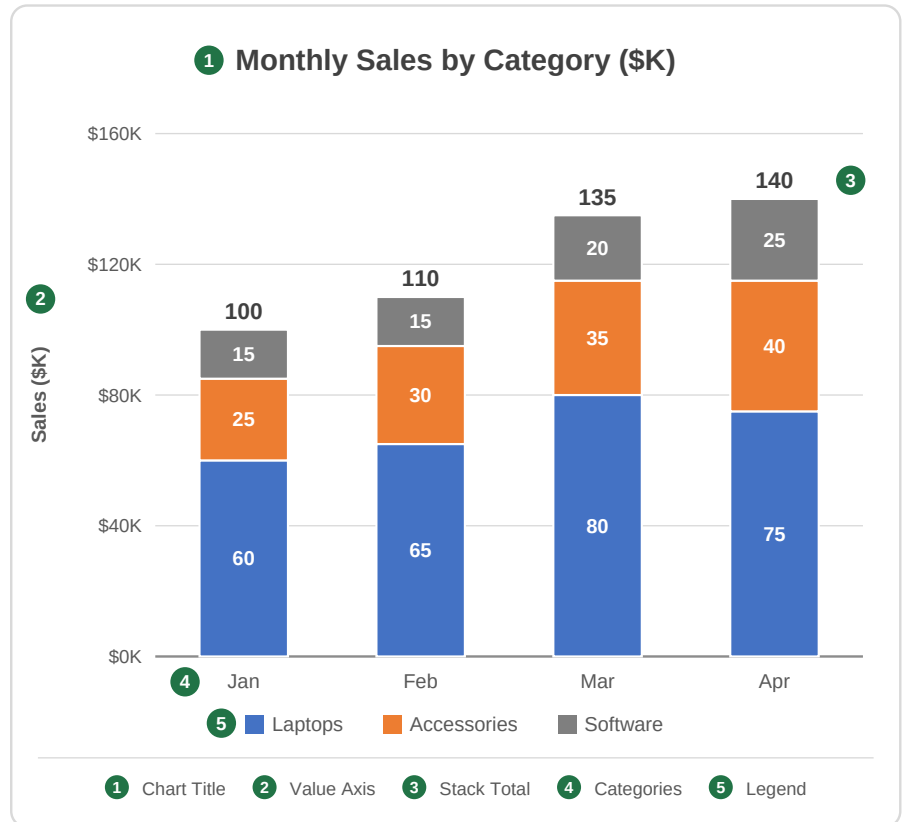
What drives monthly sales growth?

CHART

Stacked Column Chart

INSIGHT

Sales grew 40% (100K to 140K), led equally by Laptops and Accessories (+15K each).



HOW TO CREATE IT IN EXCEL



- Select** all the data, including the headers (A1:D5).
- Go to the **Insert** tab and open the **Charts** group.
- Click **Insert Column or Bar Chart** > **2-D Column** > **Stacked Column**.
- Add a clear **Chart Title** and move the legend to the bottom.
- Format**: add Data Labels, keep colours consistent, and put the key series at the bottom.

DO / DON'T

DO ✓

- ✓ Limit the stack to 3-4 categories
- ✓ Use one colour per category
- ✓ Put the key series at the bottom
- ✓ Show the total above each stack

DON'T ✗

- ✗ Stack 8+ categories
- ✗ Compare middle segments precisely
- ✗ Use similar-looking colours
- ✗ Use it when only totals matter



DATA ANALYST TIP

Use it to show total + composition, and keep the key series at the bottom.

Only the bottom segment shares a common baseline, so order your series with care.